

Using JavaScript

With the evolution of the web, designers wanted webpages to be more interactive. Since they couldn't do this with just HTML and CSS, another programming language was created.

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How it works

JavaScript (JS) is added to an HTML webpage using the script tag, and similar to CSS, code can either be written inside the tag or in its own separate file. Each user's browser acts as a JavaScript interpreter. The biggest advantage is that JS can perform calculations and make decisions without having to send information all the way back to the server. This saves a lot of time. However, the code can't run if someone disables JavaScript in their browser.

IN DEPTH

Birth of JavaScript

In 1995, American technologist Brendan Eich was hired by Netscape (a popular web browser of the time) to create a programming language for browsers. The first draft of JavaScript was completed in only 10 days. As a result, the language has several oddities that are famous for causing frustration among developers.



JavaScript tasks

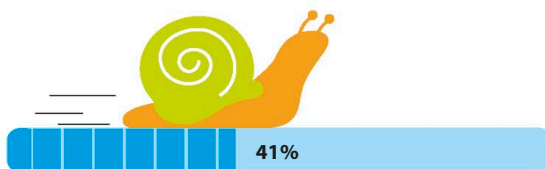
- Checking that you've filled out all the fields in an online form before sending it in
- Checking that the password field isn't empty
- Collapsing and expanding text boxes without making the page reload
- Loading images one at a time, as you need them, instead of all at once
- Allowing users to personalize their accounts
- Interactive graphics
- Video streaming

JavaScript syntax

A full programming language needs variables, functions, conditionals, and loops. Due to the popularity of Java, Netscape wanted JavaScript syntax to be similar, including brackets and semi-colons. Aside from this small detail, the two languages are completely different. JavaScript was designed to be flexible and dynamic in the tradition of languages such as Scheme.

► Limits

JavaScript's flexibility also makes it slow and unmanageable. While a mobile photo app or a scientific program could be written in JavaScript, it's not the best language for the job.



LINGO

What is a script?

A script is a code file that is executed by a program other than the computer processor. Instructions are written in a single file. Typically, scripts are used for quick, straightforward tasks, while more structured languages are used to build massive software applications. So, you might write a script to automatically change the name of thousands of picture files, or convert data from an Excel file into a Word file, or handle the animations on a webpage.